General rule – casting a spell · "Spells" chapter of the SRD 5.2.1

Level and slots. A spell has a level from 0 to 9. A level 0 spell (cantrip) is cast at will. A level 1 or higher spell requires expending a **spell slot** of equal or higher level. Casting with a higher slot can increase its effect, if its description says so. Expended slots return after a rest, depending on your class.

Casting time. Most often, the **Magic** action. Some spells use a **Bonus Action** or a **Reaction** (the description says when). Longer spells (minutes, hours) need the Magic action each turn and your **Concentration**: if it breaks, the spell fails but the slot isn't expended.

Ritual. A spell with the "Ritual" tag can be cast as a Ritual: **10 minutes longer**, with no slot (so no higher level). You need a feature that allows Rituals, and the spell prepared or in your spellbook, depending on the feature.

Armor. If you wear armor without training, you can't cast spells.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. You pick a **prepared** (or known) spell and a suitable slot.
2. You check the **casting time** and **components** (V, S, M).
3. You choose a **target or area** within range, with a clear path.
4. You expend the slot, then resolve: **spell attack** or **saving throw**.
5. You manage the **duration**: instantaneous, Concentration, or limited.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't always say how to handle edge cases (a target partly behind cover, spells with multiple effects). Fix: the DM announces his choices before the game.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the gestures, the strange words, the glow rising before the spell leaves.

Step 1 – Choose the spell:

Only a **prepared** (or known, depending on class) spell can be cast. The slot's level determines any higher-level effect.

Step 2 – Casting time:

Magic action by default; **Bonus Action**: one spell per turn, except an action cantrip; **Reaction**: per the spell's trigger; **longer**: Magic action each turn, Concentration.

Step 3 – Components:

Verbal: you must speak. **Somatic**: a free hand for gestures. **Material**: specific objects, or a focus; you need a free hand to get them. A component is consumed only if the spell says so. A focus replaces components without a cost.

Step 4 – Target and range:

The target must be within **range** (distance, touch, self) and you need a **clear path**: total cover blocks it. You can target yourself unless stated otherwise.

Step 5 – Resolve:

Spell attack: d20 + spellcasting ability modifier + Proficiency Bonus against AC. **Saving throw**: DC = 8 + modifier + Proficiency Bonus. Spells can deal damage, create a condition, or both.

Step 6 – Duration:

Instantaneous: no follow-up. **Concentration**: one Concentration spell at a time; it ends if you cast another Concentration spell, if you are Incapacitated or die, or if you fail a Constitution save when you take damage.

Example: Éloïse (Wizard, DC 15) casts Fireball with a level 4 slot. She expends the slot, picks a point within 150 ft, and each creature in the Sphere makes a Dexterity save against 15. Damage is 9d6.

Areas of effect:

An area's origin must be visible or reachable, with no total cover between it and the caster.

Area	Shape
Cone	Starts at you and widens as it moves away.
Cube	A cube whose origin is a face (or a point).
Cylinder	A circle on the ground with a height.
Emanation	Starts from you and follows you; the area is centered on you.
Line	A straight line of a given length and width.
Sphere	A ball centered on a point.

Durations:

Duration	Rule
Instantaneous	The effect happens and the spell ends.
Concentration	One at a time. Lost if you cast another Concentration spell, are Incapacitated or die, or fail a Constitution save on damage.
Up to X	Limited duration; no Concentration unless stated.
Voluntary end	The caster can end a non-instantaneous spell.

Concentration save:

When you take damage, Constitution save: **DC 10 or half the damage** (whichever is higher), at most **DC 30**. One save per source of damage.

Combining effects:

Effects of different spells add together. Effects of the same spell cast several times don't stack: only the strongest applies.

⚠ Common questions:

How many spells can I cast per turn?
No fixed limit, but you have one action and expend only one slot per turn.

Can I cast a cantrip and a Bonus Action spell?
Yes: the cantrip uses no slot and is cast with an action.

Can a Reaction spell be cast during my turn?
Yes, but only one slot per turn.

Is the Material component consumed?
Only if the spell's description says so.

Does a focus replace everything?
No: only components with no cost that aren't consumed.

Do I need a free hand?
Yes for Material components or a focus; the same hand can serve Somatic components.

Can I cast a spell without a slot?
It is then cast at its lowest level, unless stated otherwise.

Can I concentrate on a Ritual?
You must concentrate during casting if it takes longer than one action.

⚠ Debate points and table options:

Table rule

Cantrip after a Bonus Action spell
A one-action cantrip is allowed. **Option**: apply the text as is.

Clear path
The SRD requires a clear path but doesn't detail partial obstacles. **Option**: the DM decides based on line of sight.

Concentration and allies
The spell continues without sight of the caster. **Option**: keep it.

Ritual and armor
A Ritual requires the same components. **Option**: keep it.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

One expenditure per turn
You have one action and one slot per turn; a Bonus Action spell and a one-action cantrip are possible together.

Reaction during your turn
A Reaction spell can be cast during your turn, with the same one-slot limit.

Consumed components
A spell consumes only what its description says; a focus doesn't replace a consumed component.

Hands
One free hand serves Somatic components, Material components, and the focus.

Concentration
You keep Concentration without sight or range, unless the spell requires it. Temporary HP absorb damage but count for the DC.

Spell without a slot
A spell cast without a slot is cast at its lowest level.

Spell attack
A spell attack can be a Critical Hit. A touch-range spell isn't a melee attack by that fact. A spell attack isn't the Attack action or an Opportunity Attack.

Multiple attacks
Several targets: each attack is resolved separately, even if targets are chosen in advance.

Dispel
Dispel Magic affects only spells; permanent effects can be dispelled unless stated otherwise.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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